

Olympics, will give him some breathing room. But he will also know that he will need to act swiftly if India is to avoid slipping further behind the rest of the world.

The same cannot be said for the women's team, however. Expectations were low-key for a side that only began to take shape under the returning head coach Sjoerd Marijne seven months ago.

But in a short period, the progress can be measured both in results and performances, with 11 tournament debutants. Put in a tough group involving China and England, the World No. 9 side pipped the latter to break into the top eight. With a 5th-6th classification game to come, the women's side is on track for its best World Cup finish since the inaugural edition in 1974.

After turbulent spells under Janneke Schopmann and Harendra Singh, Marijne has brought some familiarity and much-needed belief, which was previously lacking. "The team's environment has changed a lot. It's a healthy environment where everyone can speak, everyone can laugh, and questions are asked for their improvement," Savita Punia, the senior-most member of the team, told *Sportstar*.

India started with an impressive 2-2 draw against World No. 4 China, before holding England to a goalless draw. In the five matches it played, it lost



just once, to three-time reigning champion Netherlands, which was made to work hard for its win.

Bichu Devi, who has stood up in Savita's absence in recent times, continued her rise with another solid showing, adding another career highlight with a last-minute save against England that ensured India's progress into the second round.

Several young players, including Sakshi Rana, Sunelita Toppo, Deepika (facing page, below) and Ishika, impressed.

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Steady rise: Expectations were low-key for the women's side, which only began to take shape under returning head coach Sjoerd Marijne (centre) seven months ago. But in a short period, its progress has been evident in both results and performance. HOCKEY INDIA

tournament experience also cost the side, with Shilpi Dabas conceding a penalty stroke in the draw against China and the team producing an error-strewn performance in the goalless draw against Australia, which ended its semifinal hopes. The over-reliance on Navneet Kaur (left), India's joint top scorer with Deepika, for goals ultimately caught up with it.

There will be plenty to learn from this exposure for Marijne's transitional side, which will head into the Asiad hoping to upset China once again and go for gold.

The furore over the new kits died down as both teams started on a positive note in them. But the irony was hard to miss: in orange, India lost all three matches against teams wearing blue.

